

4,499 TONS The amount of supplies airdropped by US and South Vietnamese planes during the 55-day siege of An Loc.



War companions

US adviser Lieutenant Colonel Burr M. Willey, accompanied by his dog Moose, fires his rifle as he moves up Route 13 toward An Loc with a South Vietnamese army unit. Willey and his dog later died in the relief effort.

Artillery bombardment

What became the siege of An Loc began on April 12 with an NVA attack, accompanied by a 7,000-shell barrage. ARVN soldiers initially ran away from the T-54 tanks, but soon discovered the effectiveness of both their shoulder-fired light antitank weapons (LAWs) and the support of US gunship helicopters. In spite of their efforts, however, the ARVN lost the northern half of the town.

General Tra made a second wave attack on April 19. By then, the ARVN's First Airborne Brigade had reached nearby positions and joined the defense, taking charge of recovering the airdropped supplies. On April 29, Tra's troops employed the SA-7 anti-aircraft missile, forcing the air drops to a high altitude that demanded special parachute techniques.

Tra then assembled his troops for another pitched attack on May 11. As the NVA crowded into An Loc, with second echelon forces concentrated behind them, General Abrams ordered a full day of B-52 strikes on the town. The destruction blunted the North Vietnamese attack. From that moment, South Vietnamese efforts shifted to the restoration of ground links between Saigon and An Loc. The Siege of An Loc ended on June 1.